

How You Got Happiness?: Part I - Does Pleasure Bring Happiness

J. Krishnamurti

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Chapter 1

Does Pleasure Bring Happiness?

This chapter follows J. Krishnamurti's dialogue with Dr. Alan W. Anderson on pleasure, enjoyment, joy, happiness, thought, attention, discipline, and freedom, based on the Krishnamurti Foundation Trust source material and curated by LazyingArt LLC. There is no blackboard mathematics in this lecture. The displayed formulae and diagrams are therefore transcript-based schemata: compact reconstructions of the inquiry's structure, meant to preserve the order of the spoken investigation without turning it into psychology, doctrine, or method.

1.1 The Question Pleasure Cannot Evade

Anderson opens by returning to the previous conversation. The inquiry has moved through fear and has arrived at pleasure. At once several words stand together: pleasure, enjoyment, delight, joy, happiness. The easy assumption would be that these form a family, perhaps even a scale, as if pleasure could be refined into joy and joy into happiness.

Krishnamurti slows that assumption down. The issue is not whether ordinary language sometimes places pleasure and joy near one another. The issue is whether, in actual inward movement, there is any continuity between them. We can record the opening uncertainty as

$$\text{pleasure} \quad ? \quad \text{enjoyment} \quad ? \quad \text{joy} \quad ? \quad \text{happiness}. \quad (1.1)$$

The question marks do real work. The lecture begins by refusing to let vocabulary settle a question that must be seen directly.

Anderson notices the linguistic relation between “please” and “pleasure.” To say “please sit down” is not merely to command; it has the flavor of invitation, of being pleased, perhaps of pleasure. Krishnamurti hears the point, but he does not let the inquiry remain at the level of usage. He asks whether there is, beyond the word, a real connecting line:

$$\text{pleasure} \longrightarrow \text{joy} \quad ? \quad (1.2)$$

The arrow is not asserted. It is the thing under investigation.

1.1.1 Question & Answer

Question. Is pleasure a continuation of joy, a lower form of joy, or a movement that can eventually become happiness?

Answer. Krishnamurti suspends that assumption. Pleasure may share vocabulary with enjoyment and joy, but the dialogue asks whether pleasure has a different structure. Before joy can be defined, pleasure has to be examined: what is it, what sustains it, and what happens when it is pursued?

1.2 Pleasure As Pursuit And Possession

Krishnamurti does not begin with an elevated pleasure. He places ordinary and disturbing examples side by side: eating, walking, accumulating money, sex, hurting another, having power, possessing a house, possessing knowledge, possessing the idea of God, or exercising political brutality. This ordering is deliberate. Pleasure is not defined by the nobility or ugliness of its object. It is defined by its movement.

The common structure is that pleasure is sustained, nourished, and kept going. In the compressed notation of these notes,

$$\text{pleasure} = \text{the movement of thought in a direction.} \quad (1.3)$$

This is not a formal law. It is a way of preserving Krishnamurti's distinction: pleasure is thought moving toward having, repeating, continuing, enlarging, or defending something.

The examples of possession make the structure especially clear. A child may take pleasure in a toy, an adult in a house, a scholar in knowledge, a religious mind in the idea of God, and a dictator in power. The objects change, but the movement has the same outline:

$$\text{object seen or held} \longrightarrow \text{wanting it,} \quad (1.4)$$

$$\text{wanting it} \longrightarrow \text{possession,} \quad (1.5)$$

$$\text{possession} \longrightarrow \text{pleasure sustained.} \quad (1.6)$$

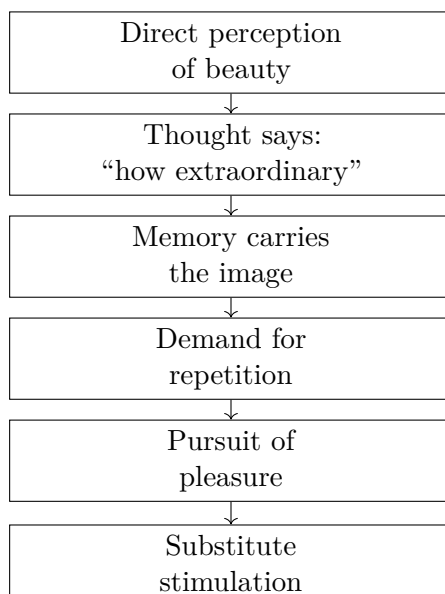
When this movement is blocked, it does not remain harmless. Krishnamurti names the sequence directly:

$$\text{thwarted pleasure} \longrightarrow \text{frustration} \longrightarrow \text{anger, jealousy, violence.} \quad (1.7)$$

The notation should be read as a disciplined reminder of the spoken order, not as a mechanical theory of behavior. The point is that pursued pleasure, when denied, becomes conflict.

1.3 The Tree, Memory, And Repetition

To make the inquiry concrete, Krishnamurti turns to a simple scene: a single tree on a hill, a green meadow, water, deer, flowers, and shadow. One sees it. In that first seeing there is no analysis, no possession, no inward commentator saying, "I must keep this." There is direct perception.



Transcript-based reconstruction of the movement from perception to the pursuit of pleasure.

Then one turns away. Thought enters and says, in effect: how extraordinary that was; I must have it again. The lecture’s central derivation begins here. The first moment is not pleasure as pursuit. Pleasure arises when thought takes the perception into memory and demands repetition.

Worked reconstruction. We can reconstruct the movement in the following steps:

1. There is direct perception of beauty.
2. Thought names the event afterward: it was extraordinary.
3. Memory carries the perception as an image.
4. Desire asks for the image to be repeated.
5. The pursuit of repetition becomes pleasure.
6. When repetition fails, substitute stimulation begins.

In compact form:

$$\text{perception} \longrightarrow \text{thought} \longrightarrow \text{memory} \longrightarrow \text{repetition} \longrightarrow \text{pursuit}. \quad (1.8)$$

The decisive distinction is between perception and the later demand for continuity. In the first seeing of the tree, hill, water, and shadow, there is perception. Pleasure begins when thought returns and says: again.

Anderson’s examples of the encore and the festival widen the point. Repetition is not merely private. Culture can organize itself around the attempt to repeat intensity: the encore, the festival, the effort to “live it up,” followed by the ordinary descent back into routine. Krishnamurti accepts this as the same movement. Thought nourishes pleasure and gives it direction.

Term	Working distinction in the dialogue
Pleasure	Thought-sustained movement in a direction; linked to memory, repetition, and pursuit.
Enjoyment	Immediate enjoyment; becomes pleasure when thought demands more.
Delight	Direct freshness, not yet organized as pursuit.
Joy	Not invited, not repeated by will, not a continuity of pleasure.
Happiness	Not known as an object while present; named only afterward.

Transcript-based distinction among the central terms.

1.4 Enjoyment, Joy, And The Movement Of Thought

The lecture now returns to the opening question with sharper tools. If pleasure is thought moving in a direction, what is its relation to enjoyment, delight, joy, and happiness?

Krishnamurti's answer is exact:

$$\text{enjoyment} + \text{thought}(\text{"I must have more"}) \longrightarrow \text{pleasure.} \quad (1.9)$$

Enjoyment becomes pleasure when thought appropriates it and demands continuation. Joy and happiness are not invited in this way. They are not produced by demand, held by memory, or repeated by will. One may say afterward that there was happiness, but in the moment itself there is no self-conscious possession of happiness.

1.4.1 Question & Answer

Question. When does enjoyment become pleasure?

Answer. Enjoyment becomes pleasure when thought says, "I have enjoyed it; I must have more of it." The change is not in the original enjoying, but in the entry of thought, memory, image, demand, and direction.

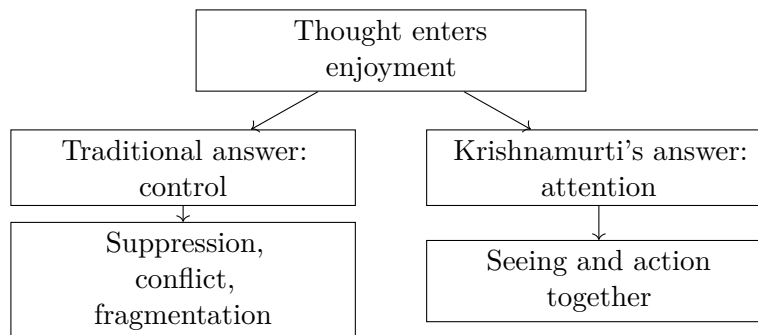
Question. Does pleasure therefore have a relation to joy or happiness?

Answer. In this dialogue, no continuity is granted. Pleasure belongs to thought moving in a direction. Joy and happiness are not manufactured by that movement. They cannot be invited, accumulated, or repeated.

The immediate consequence is another question. Can the mind register beauty and end it there? Can it see the tree, the sunset, the line of a car, and not ask for repetition? This is where the inquiry turns toward attention.

1.5 Attention Instead Of Control

If thought interferes with enjoyment, the traditional answer is to control thought. Krishnamurti presents that answer in order to reject it. Religious discipline has often meant suppressing thought,



Transcript-based reconstruction of the contrast between control and attention.

cutting it off as soon as it rises, preventing it from creeping in.

But control still belongs to division. It is thought acting against thought. It creates conflict and fragmentation. We can mark the rejected path as

$$\text{thought interferes} \longrightarrow \text{control thought} \longrightarrow \text{suppression, conflict, fragmentation.} \quad (1.10)$$

The alternative is not negligence. It is complete attention. Anderson clarifies that this has nothing to do with tightening the body or forcing concentration. Krishnamurti's phrase is simple: be wholly there. In such attention, thought does not enter as the demand to repeat.

Thus the positive structure is

$$\text{complete attention} \longrightarrow \text{no demand for repetition} \longrightarrow \text{action without control.} \quad (1.11)$$

1.5.1 Question & Answer

Question. If thought turns enjoyment into the pursuit of pleasure, must thought be controlled?

Answer. No. Control is another divided movement. Krishnamurti's answer is complete attention. This attention is not a method of concentration, not muscular effort, and not a cultivated technique. It is whole seeing.

The poisonous bottle example gives the point a practical form. If one sees that a bottle is poisonous, one does not need to control the impulse to drink it. Clear perception is already action. Control becomes necessary only when the thing has not been read clearly.

Krishnamurti then compresses the matter:

$$\text{watching} \equiv \text{discipline} \equiv \text{action.} \quad (1.12)$$

The equivalence sign is only a notation for the spoken compression. It is not a formal identity. It means that actual watching is not a preliminary to discipline or action; in the seeing itself there is order and action.

1.6 Intelligence Without Possession

Anderson then presses a subtle possibility. If attention acts without control, if watching has its own discipline, perhaps there is some abiding support behind it. Perhaps there is something permanent,

some inner source, sustaining the person.

Krishnamurti refuses the formulation. It opens the door to God, higher self, Atman, or a permanent entity within. The refusal is not incidental. It prevents the inquiry from becoming metaphysical consolation. Intelligence is not a possession. It is not something one has and then permits to operate.

The cautious reconstruction is

$$\text{observation} + \text{attention} + \text{careful seeing} \longrightarrow \text{intelligence.} \quad (1.13)$$

Even this arrow must be read carefully. It does not mean that observation is a technique for producing intelligence. It means that, in actual seeing, intelligence is present.

1.6.1 Question & Answer

Question. Is intelligence an inner support, a higher self, or a permanent source within the person?

Answer. Krishnamurti rejects that language. To speak of an abiding support risks making intelligence into an entity or doctrine. In this dialogue, intelligence comes in observation. It is sensitivity in seeing, not a metaphysical object.

This also explains why the lecture refuses the idea that one must pass through every experience in order to understand it. Krishnamurti asks, in effect: must one get drunk to see the movement of drunkenness? No. One can observe the whole movement without becoming it. Seeing is not the accumulation of experience; it is direct perception of structure.

This refusal of possession continues in the story of the monk. The monk claims achievement because he has controlled his senses, body, thoughts, and desires. He has followed the path and says, “I have got it.” Krishnamurti asks whether one can hold the sea in one’s hand. Once the water is held, it is no longer the sea. The same holds for the breeze, the earth, and truth. What is held may be only words. The story is not a digression; it exposes the pleasure of spiritual possession.

1.7 Discipline Means Learning

After the refusal of control and possession, the word discipline has to be rebuilt. In ordinary religious or moral language, discipline often means conformity, suppression, adjustment to a pattern, or obedience to a method. Krishnamurti returns the word to learning.

The corrected relation is

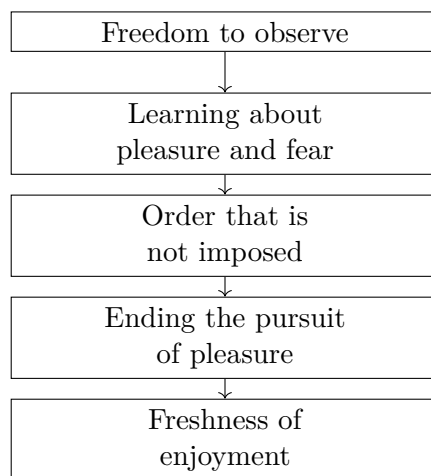
$$\text{discipline} = \text{learning.} \quad (1.14)$$

Learning here is not the accumulation of information. It is the active capacity to hear, to see, to observe. Krishnamurti distinguishes cultivated capacity from the act of listening. A capacity may be developed through time; perception, in the sense used here, is immediate.

The distinction can be recorded as

$$\text{cultivated capacity} \sim \text{time,} \quad (1.15)$$

$$\text{perception} \not\sim \text{time.} \quad (1.16)$$



Transcript-based reconstruction of learning as order.

This is a conceptual notation, not physics notation. It preserves the difference in the transcript: practice may require duration, but perception is not perfected at the end of practice.

Anderson sees the implication. There has been a confusion between perception and practice, as if perception were perfected at the end of training. Krishnamurti reverses the order. Freedom is not at the end; it is at the beginning. The first step counts.

The relation between seeing, learning, and acting is therefore simultaneous:

$$\text{seeing} + \text{learning} + \text{acting} \quad \text{occur together.} \quad (1.17)$$

This is the point at which the lecture links discipline to order. Learning about pleasure brings its own order. It is not imposed order. It is not the order of control. It is the order that comes when the movement has been read.

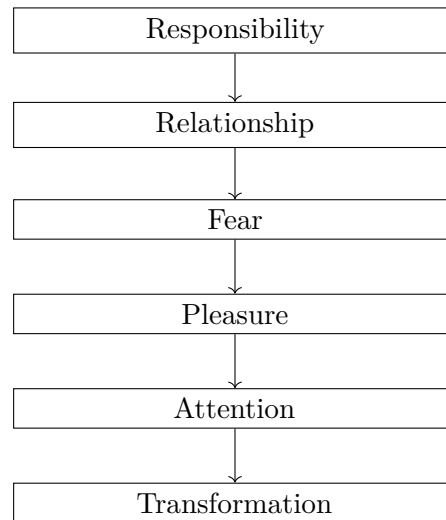
Krishnamurti also distinguishes conditioned reaction from perception-action. A person sees a snake or dangerous animal and recoils. That is self-protective conditioning; it is not yet intelligence. The deeper claim is different: where there is clear perception of the inward movement, perception and action are not separated by time. They are not the result of practice. They occur together because the seeing is whole.

1.8 Attention, Care, And The Whole Map

Near the end, the lecture broadens again. Attention is not something to be practiced, cultivated, or learned from a school. To seek a method for attention is already to miss attention. Attention includes care, affection, diligence, and the capacity to read exactly what is there without interpretation or translation.

This returns us to the title question. Does pleasure bring happiness? In the terms of this dialogue, no. Pleasure as pursuit is thought moving in a direction. It repeats, substitutes, becomes bored, seeks new directions, and may become violent when denied. Happiness and joy are not products of that movement.

Krishnamurti then gathers the larger map of the conversations: responsibility, relationship, fear, pleasure, and attention. The map is not a syllabus imposed from outside. It is the shape of the



The lecture's recap of the inquiry as a map of life.

inquiry as it has unfolded.

The final movement is quiet but decisive. Krishnamurti speaks of reading the whole map of life and of seeing what one is, not through the eyes of a professor, psychologist, guru, or book. Anderson recognizes that the conversation has stayed within the question of transformation without forcing a system. The transformation is not dependent on knowledge or time. It is bound to seeing.

The chapter therefore leaves pleasure neither condemned nor indulged. Enjoyment can end as it happens. Pleasure becomes bondage when it is carried over, repeated, and pursued. Attention reads the movement as it occurs.

1.9 Summary

The lecture begins with a question about language and ends with a map of life. Its central distinction is that pleasure is not the same as enjoyment, joy, or happiness. Pleasure begins when thought takes an immediate perception or enjoyment and turns it into memory, image, repetition, demand, and pursuit.

The main structure is

$$\text{perception} \longrightarrow \text{thought} \longrightarrow \text{memory} \longrightarrow \text{repetition} \longrightarrow \text{pleasure as pursuit.} \quad (1.18)$$

The answer is not control. Control belongs to division and suppression. The alternative is complete attention, in which seeing and action are not separated:

$$\text{attention} \longrightarrow \text{seeing and action together.} \quad (1.19)$$

From this, discipline receives a different meaning:

$$\text{discipline} = \text{learning.} \quad (1.20)$$

When the mind learns the structure of pleasure directly, that learning brings its own order. The inquiry then opens naturally toward attention, transformation, the sacred, and the later question of beauty.